

DDI Metadata for Beginners

Free, bilingual training resources to start making your data FAIR with DDI

The FAIRwithDDI Project: Implementing FAIR Principles with the DDI Standard. Metadata is essential for applying the FAIR principles, yet often hard to grasp. FAIRwithDDI's Work Package 2 creates bilingual beginner resources explaining what metadata is, how it supports FAIR practices, and introduces the DDI standard as a practical framework for structured, reusable metadata.

Data, metadata, they sound the same to me. What is the difference between data and metadata?

Data is the primary information collected during a study, an experiment, or an observation. It aims to measure concepts by collecting information that can be represented in different ways, such as numbers, text, symbols, or pictures. For data to be meaningful, it needs to have related information about what it measures and how that should be interpreted - this is what metadata captures.



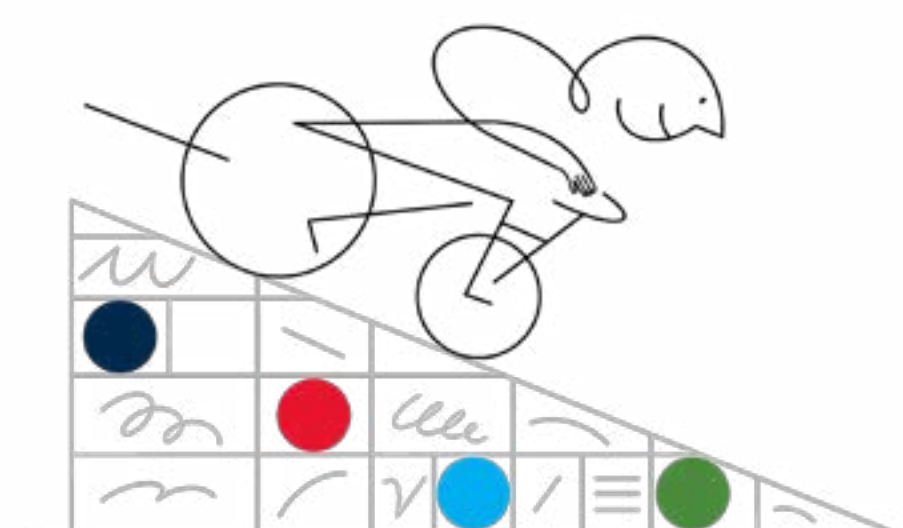
Ok, there are a lot of different standards... So why should I use DDI?

The Data Documentation Initiative (DDI) is a suite of products that describes metadata about both quantitative and qualitative research data in the social, behavioral, economic, and health sciences. DDI is an open standard that helps you document and manage different stages of the research data lifecycle, including conceptualisation, collection, process, distribution, discovery, and archiving. With DDI, you can capture all the information about your research, including a description of your study or the questions you have asked.



It is not mandatory to create metadata. Why do I need to do it? What are the benefits?

Creating robust metadata saves you time in the long run and maximises the use of your data. Without metadata, your data ends up in a silo as it is harder to discover, understand and (re)use. Researchers waste time independently seeking or giving clarification around datasets. Metadata allows people to compare and exchange information between different datasets. Data is easier to discover and understand, leading to more data citations, secondary research and cross-study comparison. It's also a useful note to self, helping you organise your data and refer to it in the future.



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→ Scan the QR code to discover the guide and challenge your metadata skills!